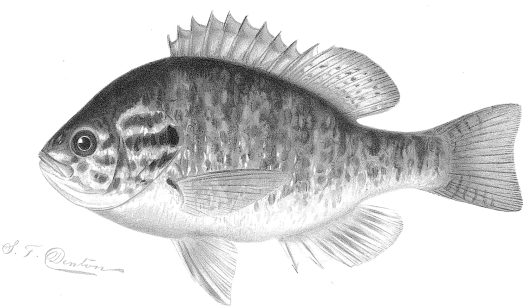


Pumpkinseed

The other sunfish on the bed

Lepomis gibbosus



Sunfish (*Eupomotis gibbosus*) — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart	An orange-red spot on the trailing edge of the black ear flap, and wavy pale-blue lines radiating back across the cheek and gill cover. The fins are speckled. There is <i>no</i> dark blotch at the back of the soft dorsal — that blotch belongs to the bluegill.
Shape	Rounder and deeper-bodied than a bluegill, with a slightly larger mouth and shorter, more rounded pectoral fins.
Size here	5–7 in. Rarely as large as a good bluegill, and usually a smaller share of the catch.
Spawn	Same window as bluegill, 65–70 °F, often on the same colonial beds — and the two species hybridize, which is why you will occasionally land something that fits neither description.
Eats	Snails above all — it has crushing teeth in its throat for them — plus insect larvae and small crustaceans.
Season	

Where and how

Habitat	Shallower and weedier than bluegill, and more tied to cover. Pine spots 6 and 1 ; North spots 1 and 7 .
Depth	1–8 ft, in and against vegetation. If you are catching bluegill on the deep weed edge and pumpkinseed on the inside edge, that is normal.
Rig	Identical to bluegill — slip bobber, split shot, size 8 or 10 hook, small piece of worm. <i>see the slip bobber sheet</i>
Counts as	Panfish, under the 25 per day aggregate limit.

Worth knowing on the bed

When you find a June sunfish colony you will usually be catching both species plus the occasional hybrid. Sorting them on the spot is a good five-minute lesson for a child: flip the gill cover into the light and look for the orange dot.

Worth knowing

It eats snails	Pumpkinseed have specialised crushing teeth in the throat — pharyngeal jaws — strong enough to break snail shells. That is a food source almost nothing else in the lake can use, and it is why they can share a bay with bluegill without competing directly.
Shallower than bluegill	Because their food is on the bottom among vegetation, pumpkinseed hold tighter to cover and shallower than the bluegill they nest alongside. Catching bluegill deep and pumpkinseed shallow in the same bay is normal.
They hybridise freely	Bluegill–pumpkinseed crosses are common wherever both nest together, which is why you will regularly land a fish that fits neither description. Look at the ear flap first, then the pectoral fin.
The ear flap is a signal	That orange-red crescent is display colouring, brightest on nesting males in June. A dull fish in October may be much harder to tell from a bluegill.
Age	A 7 in pumpkinseed is commonly six to eight years old.

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